

How to Get Arthritis Physiotherapy on the NHS

Practical NHS-backed advice on how to get arthritis physiotherapy on nhs waiting list.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: To access NHS physiotherapy for arthritis, ask your GP for a direct referral to musculoskeletal (MSK) physiotherapy, or self-refer via your local MSK service if available — around 75% of England now offers self-referral. Describe clearly how arthritis limits your daily activities to get appropriate priority.

NHS physiotherapy is one of the most effective treatments for arthritis. Here's how to navigate the referral process efficiently.

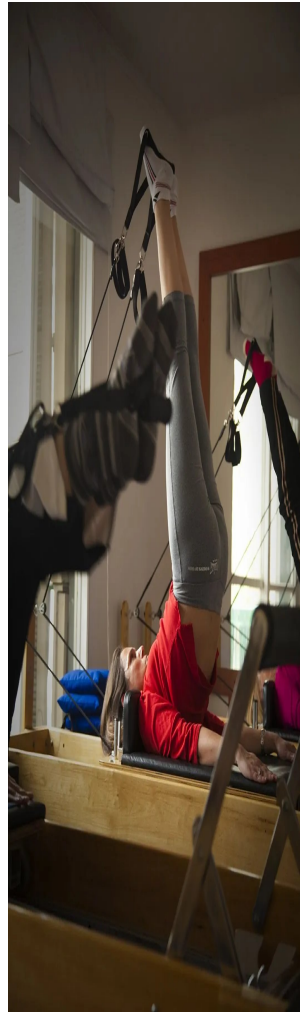
Three Routes to NHS Physiotherapy

You can access NHS physiotherapy via a GP referral, a rheumatologist referral, or direct self-referral to an MSK service. Self-referral is faster where available — you skip the GP appointment and are assessed directly by the physiotherapy team.

How to Find Self-Referral Services

- Search "MSK self-referral [your area]" online
 - Ask your GP practice receptionist if self-referral is available locally
 - Check your local NHS Trust website for physiotherapy services
 - Call 111 and ask for MSK physiotherapy guidance
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Making a Strong Referral



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Be specific about how arthritis affects your daily life. Mention specific functional limitations: "I cannot dress myself without pain," "I haven't been able to climb stairs for three months." Vague descriptions lead to lower-priority placements on waiting lists.

While You Wait

Ask your GP to prescribe anti-inflammatory medication to manage symptoms in the interim. Ask about group physiotherapy classes — these often have shorter waiting times than one-to-one appointments. Gentle movement (not complete rest) is strongly recommended while waiting.

Q&A;



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Question: Can I self-refer to NHS physiotherapy for arthritis? **Short answer:** In many areas, yes. Approximately 75% of England has direct-access MSK physiotherapy. Search for your local MSK service or ask your GP practice.

Question: How many sessions will I get on the NHS? **Short answer:** This varies by Trust and clinical need. Most people receive 6–8 sessions as a course, with access to community exercise programmes for maintenance.

Question: My GP won't refer me — what can I do? **Short answer:** Try self-referral to your local MSK service if available. If you disagree with your GP's decision, you can request a second opinion or raise a formal concern with the practice manager.